

Paranormal Investigation

Game Design Document · Working Draft

Concept Overview

You are an operator for a paranormal field investigation team. The game UI is a monitor with different panels — your team’s status, a message area, and an unfilled documentation page at the start. In real (programmed) time, your team sends messages and files about what they’re doing and what they find, while your analyst friend sends in what they turn up from their own research.

With the observations and clues you gather, you build a vocabulary that you use alongside a few basic starting phrases. You issue orders to your team through a combination system — for example, “do not + follow + familiar voice.” The team acts on default behavior on its own; you only intervene when you want them to do something different.

For example: at the 15-second mark your team reports a bedroom with the lights on and says they’re heading in. But at the 5-second mark your analyst had already sent a photo of a death where that room’s light was on — and your team has been in the dark this whole time. If you say nothing (or the wrong thing) by the 25-second mark instead of sending “do not + enter + light,” one of your team members dies.

Other interactions give clues too, so the choice isn’t always safe either way: if you say “do not enter” when it was actually fine, you may lose a clue that would have helped you later. Messages are also written so it isn’t obvious whether something is a death flag — you have to use your clues to work out what’s safe and what isn’t.

Your goal is to figure out the rules of the place so your team can escape with the documentation before they all die. You write the rules onto the documentation using the same message system, and when you submit it your team follows those rules on the way out — so if you’re wrong, you might lose people during extraction. At its core, it’s a logic-analysis game.

The Command System

Commands are built from clickable keywords and follow a fixed structure:

DO NOT (optional) + **VERB** + **NOUN**

Examples: DO NOT + ENTER + BEDROOM or SEARCH FOR + PAINTING.

A command sent before an action’s countdown reaches 0 can counter, redirect, or add to that action. A completed command can either be sent as a message to the team or added to the report as a discovered rule.

Core Gameplay Loop

1. The investigation starts.
2. Messages arrive and the analyst sends clues.
3. The player reads the clues.

4. The player builds commands.
5. The team performs or changes its actions.
6. The player adds discovered rules to the report.
7. The player submits the report.
8. The extraction sequence plays out.
9. The results screen is shown.
10. On to the next level.

Interface & HUD

The game screen is a monitor made up of several panels. A persistent HUD sits across the top:

- Team lives count (e.g., 3/4)
- Investigation name
- Signal
- Time in investigation

Signal

Signal strength affects message timing. At 100% messages arrive normally; at 40% messages are delayed, leaving the player less time on the action countdown.

UI Panels

- **Team Status** — icon, name, alive/deceased, location, action countdown, and trust percent for each member.
- **Messages** — team and analyst messages, each with a time, name, icon, and message. Certain words can be clicked to add them to the command keywords; the clickable word has a button hitbox but nothing to indicate it's a button.
- **Command Keywords** — clicking a keyword populates the Build Commands panel. Scrollable. Each keyword has a type (which sets its color), a word, and a locked/unlocked state. Unlocking a new keyword plays a small glitch effect and sound.
- **Build Commands** — holds the currently selected keywords; click a keyword to delete it. When finished, the player either sends the command (posts it in the Messages panel) or adds it as a rule (to the report). Some commands are locked, showing a hidden sprite until they're found through clues or observations.
- **Report** — the known rules, filled in from Build Commands. Five slots, though not every slot needs to be used to submit or to be correct. Scrollable, with a Submit button to finish the level. Clicking a filled-in rule deletes it (hovering shows a text outline to indicate this).
- **Clues** — appear as popup tabs the player can drag around and rearrange. A dropdown lists the clue names sent by the analyst. Clues can be photos, observations, documents, or witness statements. Clicking certain words or parts of a photo adds a keyword to the command keywords — again with no visual indication that it's a button.
- **Map** — a photo of the area labeled with room and place names (decorative).

Team & Analyst Behavior

- At programmed times (e.g., 15s, 25s) the team sends messages — some are observations, some announce an action they're about to take. There is technically only one timeline, but commands can modify events (perhaps via a true/false boolean).
- Observations may contain certain words that can be clicked to add them to the command keywords (a hidden button).
- “About to” actions for the messaging member (and anyone joining them) show on the status panel with a chosen countdown after the message is sent.
- The player can send a message that counters, redirects, or adds to an action if it's sent before the countdown reaches 0.
- For commands that do nothing, the team may respond — e.g., “couldn't find anything” for an incorrect look-for command.
- Sometimes a member sees something and takes a photo, sending it with a message and a file-download icon. Clicking the file button adds it to the Clues dropdown and plays a one-time animation to signal a new item.
- The analyst also sends messages and findings from outside and from previous encounters.
- Messages have color-coded types (question, action, analyst sending a clue).
- If a team member is dead, they no longer send messages, take actions, or give clues.

Trust

Every team member has a trust percentage. When a member dies they lose 10% trust. For every percent of trust below 100%, that character has a chance to either take longer to follow a command or refuse to follow it at all.

Completing a Level

- When the report is submitted, the team leaves while following the rules. Depending on whether the rules are right or wrong, a sequence of events plays out — and there may be a danger moment where the player must send a command before something bad happens, because of a wrong or missing rule.
- If the entire team dies, the level resets with the dead members' trust reduced by 10%.
- The results report is scored on time, known rules, the survivor list, and the keywords (“evidence”) obtained — with a rating based on accuracy, survivors, and keywords obtained.
- A button moves on to the next level, or — after the third level — to an end-credits page showing all three level reports.
- On the next level you keep the same teammates (in lore, they're reanimated by the company), but any who died in the previous level have their trust reduced by 10%.

Controls

- **P** — pauses the game. No new messages are sent, no actions are taken, and the timer stops.

UI / Scene Hierarchy

```
Monitor (Canvas)
├── Background (Image)
├── HUD (Panel)
│   ├── Investigation (Text)
│   ├── Signal (Image)
│   ├── Timer (Text)
│   └── Lives (Text)
├── Team (Panel)
│   ├── Title (Text)
│   └── Team List (Vertical Layout Group)
│       └── Team Member (Prefab ×4)
│           ├── Portrait (Image)
│           ├── Name (Text)
│           ├── Status (Text)
│           ├── Action (Text)
│           ├── Action Timer (Text)
│           ├── Location (Text)
│           └── Trust Bar (Slider)
├── Messages (Panel)
│   └── Scroll View
│       └── Content (Vertical Layout Group)
│           └── Message (Prefab)
│               ├── Icon (Image)
│               ├── Sender (Text)
│               ├── Time (Text)
│               ├── Message (Text)
│               └── Keyword Button (Optional)
├── Commands (Panel)
│   ├── Keyword (Prefab)
│   │   ├── Locked Icon (Optional)
│   │   └── Button
│   └── Build Commands (Panel)
│       └── Command Slot ×3
│           ├── Background (Image)
│           ├── Keyword (Text)
│           └── Remove (Button)
├── Clues (Panel)
│   ├── Dropdown
│   ├── Clue Entry (Prefab)
│   │   ├── Name (Text)
│   │   ├── Background (Image)
│   │   └── Select (Button)
│   ├── Clue Viewer (Prefab)
│   │   ├── Image (Optional)
│   │   ├── Text (Optional)
│   │   └── Keyword Button (Prefab) (Optional)
│   └── Notification Popup (Sprite)
├── Report (Panel)
│   ├── Survival Rules
│   │   └── Rule Slot ×5
│   │       ├── Rule Text
│   │       └── Remove Button
│   └── Submit (Button)
└── Map (Panel)
    └── Map (Image)
```

Popups

- Pause
- Results

Programming Design

Audio Manager

- Plays background music and the keyword-gained sound effect.

Gameplay Manager

State

- Final time: initialized to 0.
- Command word 1, 2, 3 text: initialized to “”.
- Command slots 1, 2, 3.
- Rule phrase 1–5 text: initialized to “”.
- Rule phrase slots 1–5.
- Paused boolean.
- Final boolean.

Methods

- **Start game:** initialize the level based on input and start the timer.
- **Send message:** create a new instance of a prefab from the given message object and place it in the content object in the UI. If it has a clue input, activate the download button on the prefab and set its click input to the clue object. Change the message text color based on type. Set the completed boolean to true. If there is an action, wait the action-timer amount and check whether the action is still active; if it is, perform the outcome. If the outcome is a death result, set that team member’s status to dead.
- **Download clue click:** create a clue prefab from the clue object’s information and attach it to the clue prefab. Instantiate an evidence-button prefab if the clue object has a button. In the clue viewer, set every clue prefab inactive and the new one active. Add a clue-name prefab to the dropdown using the clue name.
- **Dropdown click:** when the dropdown is clicked, show the display of all clue names.
- **Clue click:** when a clue in the dropdown is clicked, hide all clue names, set every other clue prefab inactive, and activate the one associated with that name.
- **Instant-message check:** constantly check whether any message is active and instant; if so, send it via Send message.
- **Timed-message check:** constantly check whether any message is active and whether (time – final time) exceeds its time-to-send; if so, send it via Send message. If a message carrying an action object is sent, set that action object’s active boolean to true, and set the clue input to the message’s clue object.
- **Report function:** when Submit is pressed, set every message scriptable object whose “final” boolean is false to inactive, and every one whose “final” boolean is true to active. Mark the current time and save it in the final time variable.
- **Command word click:** if a slot is available (is “”), set the first available command slot’s text to the input command word.
- **Add rule click:** if a rule slot is available (is “”), set the first available rule slot’s text to the phrase built from the three command words (with spaces after words 1 and 2).
- **Delete rule click:** set that rule’s text back to “”.
- **Send command click:** create a new message prefab with the avatar icon, sender “Operator,” and the message built from the three command words (with spaces after words 1 and 2). Check whether the

completed phrase matches any add/redirect/counter command text on action scriptable objects whose countdown is active and greater than 0; if so, set the associated action object's active boolean to false.

- **Results check:** constantly check whether the final boolean is true and all messages with the final boolean and completed boolean are true. If so, open the results popup: alive team members, unlocked keywords out of total, total investigation time, and a button to advance to the next level (or end the game after the 3rd level).
- **Keyword-word click:** when the mouse clicks a message word that is a keyword, unlock that keyword.
- **Unlock keyword:** activate the keyword button and remove the locked image.
- **Image clue click:** unlock the keyword associated with the button, then set the button inactive.

Scriptable Objects

Message

- Active boolean
- Completed boolean (initialized false)
- Instant boolean
- Time to send (optional)
- Team member object
- Message
- Action text
- Final boolean
- Event type (enum: message, action, clue, system)
- Action object (if action type; can be null)
- Clue object (for clue type; can be null)

Team Member

- Name
- Icon
- Trust
- Alive
- Current action
- Location
- Action timer

Action

- Active boolean (initialized false)
- Countdown seconds
- Counter command text (can be null)
- Add command text (can be null)
- Redirect command text (can be null)
- Counter message object (can be null)
- Add message object (can be null)

- Redirect message object (can be null)
- Countdown message
- Death countdown boolean

For an action message there may be a counter, add, and/or redirect (any one, or all three). If the player sends a message matching one of these before the countdown finishes, the respective message object is set active and sent. If nothing matching is sent by the time the countdown ends, the countdown message is set active and sent instead.

Investigation

- Name
- Map
- Messages list
- Actions list
- Starting keywords

Clue

- Name text
- Image (can be null)
- Text (can be null)
- Button object (can be null)

Button

- Keyword
- Position
- Size

Keyword

- Word
- Unlocked boolean
- Locked image

Design Notes & To-Do

To add

- When a specific area of a photo clue — or a specific word in a message/text clue — is clicked, it unlocks the associated keyword in the Commands panel: the button becomes active for command-word clicks and the locked image on top of it is removed.

Early ideas & scratch notes

- Action words are given; possibly unlock specific object words.
- Find things in pictures; do short minigames.
- **Care for your team:** carry the team over from the previous level; extra recruits; a tab showing random profiles of the team; characters speak in a certain way; ghosts block names so you infer who is speaking; context-independent messages; the analyst sends messages.
- **Care for yourself:** (not yet developed).

- Visualize through a minimap with locations written out (e.g., members John, Cary, Tim across rooms R1–R4).
- Misc: status updates; messages as scriptable objects; text creation / text finding.